ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

THA 213: Theatre History from the Renaissance to the 19th Century

How revolutions, technology and money rebuilt the stage

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 200L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

This pack links theatre change to political and industrial change: the Renaissance recovery of classical texts, the rise of commercial playhouses, the director, melodrama, minstrel shows and new stage technology. It also shows you how the history sequence was renumbered between the 2018 and 2019 departmental listings.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Trace major European theatre developments from the Renaissance to 1900.
- Explain how industrial and political change shaped theatre architecture and production.
- Connect the rise of the director to changes in staging and rehearsal.
- Interpret the archive entries showing how the department reorganised this course.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Renaissance to Enlightenment

Recovered classical texts changed what could be staged and how.

- Humanist scholarship revived Roman comedy and Senecan tragedy.
- Commedia dell'arte professionalised touring improvisation.
- Court masque and spectacle fused design, music and politics.
- Neoclassical rules constrained structure until Romantic practice broke them.
- Purpose-built playhouses created a paying public and a commercial profession.

- Printing made plays available as literature, not only as performance.

Revolution, industry and melodrama

The 19th century is the hinge between repertory theatre and modern production.

- Political revolution changed censorship, audiences and subject matter.
- Gas and later electric lighting enabled picture-stage realism and controlled mood.
- Railways created touring circuits and star actors with national reputations.
- Melodrama offered clear morality, spectacle and music to mass audiences.
- Minstrel shows spread racist caricature while shaping popular entertainment formats.
- Realism and naturalism responded with claims to scientific observation.

> **Technology is dramaturgy**
> Lighting, scene-shifting machinery and proscenium staging did not merely decorate plays; they changed what writers could write.

The rise of the director

Directing emerged as a profession when production became too complex for the actor-manager alone.

- Ensemble coherence replaced star-centred staging in key companies.
- Rehearsal became a structured period rather than a formality.
- Designers and directors coordinated unified visual concepts.
- Scripts were interpreted rather than simply recited.
- The director's authority also centralised power in production.
- This history explains why directing is a separate course in your programme.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 213

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 113 Theatre History in Perspective: 500 BC - 1800 AD appears in the 2018 descriptions
- Covers myth, folklore, songs, riddles and legends growing into written plays
- Questions whether theatre "evolved", "developed" or was "made" in various contexts

What changed: THA 113 is the older history code. It appears in the 2018 description and is absent from the 2019 programme listing.

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 213 Critical Perspectives in Theatre History: Renaissance to 19th Century, 3 credits
- Covers the Industrial Revolution, nationalisms, Romanticism, melodrama, minstrel shows, acting companies and the rise of the director
- New theatre architecture and design included in the same course

What changed: The 2019 listing replaces the broad 500 BC - 1800 AD survey with a Renaissance-to-19th-century course at 200 level.

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- The Renaissance-to-19th-century framing survives in the compiled 2025/2026 map
- Industrialisation, lighting technology and the emergence of the director remain examined themes
- Check whether THA 113-style world history is now covered in THA 111 or THA 112

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. How did gas lighting change theatre practice?

Answer: It allowed controllable dimming and focus, making picture-stage realism and mood shifts possible and changing rehearsal and design practice.

2. Why did the director emerge as a profession in the 19th century?

Answer: Growing production complexity, ensemble ideals and unified visual concepts required someone to coordinate staging, design and interpretation.

3. What characterises melodrama?

Answer: Clear moral polarities, heightened emotion, music, spectacle and stock situations designed for mass audiences.

4. Name one effect of the printing press on drama.

Answer: Plays circulated as read literature, extending their influence beyond performance and shaping ideas of authorship.

5. What did neoclassical rules require?

Answer: Adherence to unity of time, place and action, decorum and clear moral instruction, modelled on classical precedent.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Build a timeline from 1500 to 1900 with ten theatre events.
- [ ] Explain three effects of industrialisation on theatre.
- [ ] Compare pre- and post-lighting scene changes.
- [ ] Learn five melodrama conventions with an example.
- [ ] Trace how the director's role emerged in two countries.
- [ ] Read one play from the period and note its staging demands.
- [ ] Summarise the archive change from THA 113 to the current sequence.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

> **More from the ZikShare Academic Vault**
> Find faculty primers, study-skills guides, money and career packs, and digital-skills workbooks in the ZikShare Library. New packs are added every semester.

ZikShare Academic Vault | Theatre & Film Studies | 200L | 2026 Fresher Edition

YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

THA 213: Theatre History from the Renaissance to the 19th Century